

Conflict in Relationships

Emotional flooding

Emotional flooding

- During a conflict, negative emotions become so overwhelming that cognition is impaired.
 - And people may say things they don't really mean and/or regret later.
- When someone is experiencing emotional flooding, it takes about 20 minutes for their brain to return to its normal state.

Emotional flooding

- What happens during emotional flooding?
 - Psychological arousal (increased heart rate and blood pressure)
 - Difficulty processing information
 - Difficulty thinking clearly
- Brain becomes overwhelmed with cortisol, epinephrine (adrenaline), and norepinephrine
- Rational thinking shuts down – fight or flight

Studying conflict



Is there a way of predicting which conflict style a couple will use?

Yes.

Attribution theory provides some insight into this issue.

Attribution theory

Individuals have a fundamental need to determine the cause of others' behaviors.

- Especially in conflict.
- Three key questions.

Attribution theory

1. Personal vs. situational

- Is the cause of this conflict a personality flaw (personal) or is the cause of the conflict due to the circumstances we are in (situational)?

Attribution theory

2. Unstable vs. stable

- Is this behavior that is making me upset atypical (unstable) or typical (stable)

Attribution theory

3. Global vs. specific

- Is the behavior that is making me mad apparent elsewhere (global) or does it just apply to this particular situation (specific)?

Attribution theory

Situational + unstable + specific attributions tend to predict the use of more positive conflict styles

- Collaborating and compromising

Personal + stable + global attributions tend to predict more negative conflict styles.

- Competitive fighting, indirect fighting

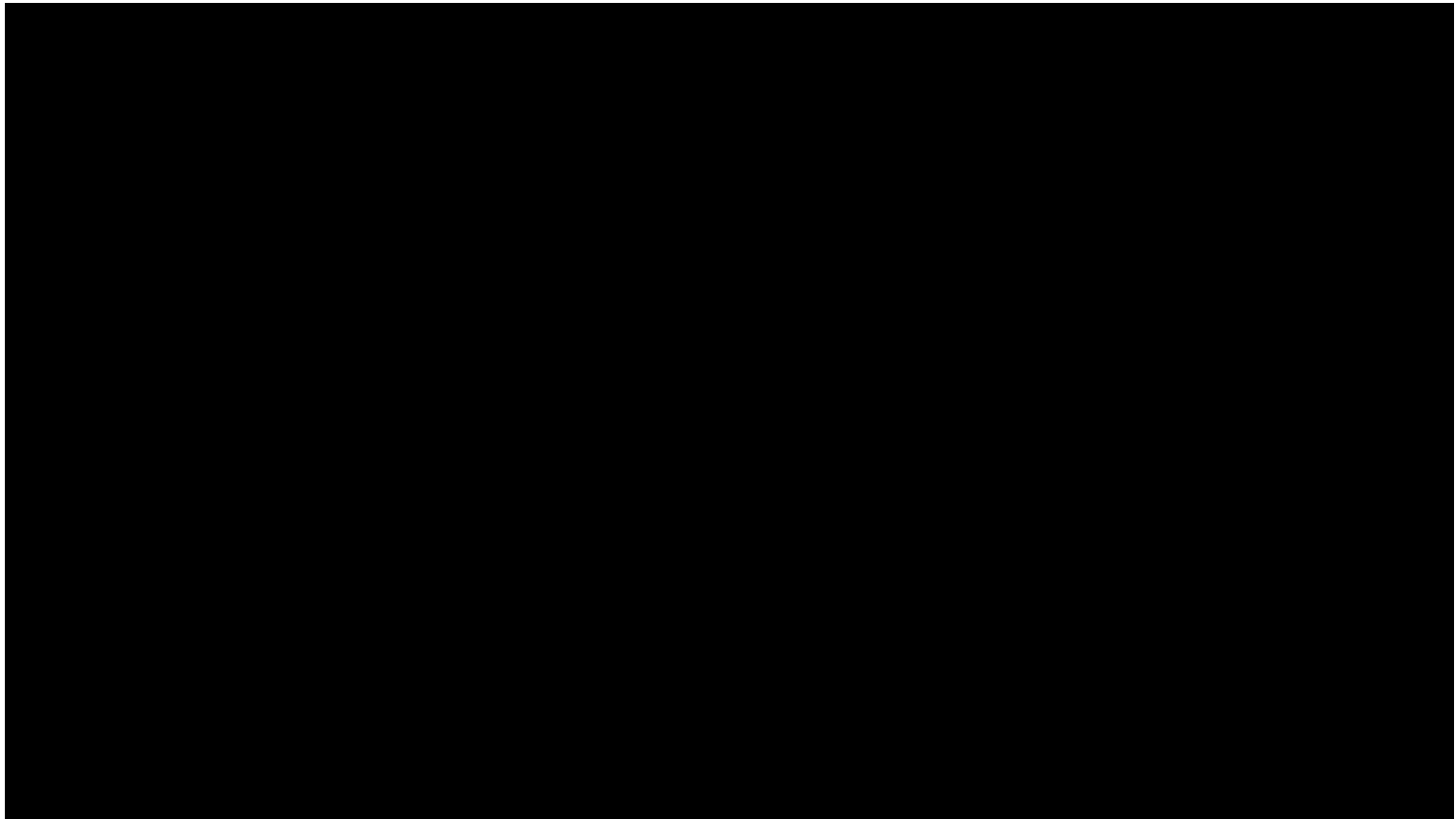
Accommodation

Accommodation

- responding to a partner's destructive act by **inhibiting the impulse** to reciprocate with another destructive act.
 - Resisting negative reciprocity
 - This helps to defuse a negative situation

Children and relationship satisfaction/conflict

- When a couple has children, relationship satisfaction declines and conflict increases (Doss et al., 2009).
- In most cases, parenthood does not bring people closer (Hansen, 2012).
- Parenthood changes how couples interact (Johnson, 2016).
 - Communication becomes more business-like.



Gottman's solvable vs. unsolvable problems

Solvable problems refer to issues or conflicts in a relationship that, with effective communication and problem-solving skills, can be resolved to the satisfaction of both partners.

- These problems tend to be specific, concrete, and often related to day-to-day matters. They may involve issues like household chores, financial decisions, or time management.

Gottman's solvable vs. unsolvable problems

Resolution of solvable problems

- Couples can work together to find compromises, make specific plans, or establish clear agreements to address solvable problems. This may involve brainstorming solutions, evaluating options, and reaching a mutually acceptable resolution.
- Examples of solvable problems might include disagreements over how to divide household responsibilities, how to manage finances, or how to coordinate schedules.

Gottman's solvable vs. unsolvable problems

Unsolvable problems refer to issues or conflicts in a relationship that, due to fundamental differences in values, personality traits, or deeply ingrained preferences, may not have a clear, mutually satisfying resolution.

- These problems tend to be more enduring and related to core aspects of each partner's identity, beliefs, or desires. They may involve differences in life goals, values, or personality traits.

Gottman's solvable vs. unsolvable problems

Management and coping of unsolvable problems

- Rather than seeking a solution, couples must learn to manage and cope with unsolvable problems. This may involve accepting differences, finding ways to support each other, and developing strategies to minimize conflict around these issues.
- Examples of unsolvable problems might include differences in religious beliefs, fundamental values, or differing desires regarding having children.

Gottman's solvable vs. unsolvable problems

Understanding the distinction between solvable and unsolvable problems can be crucial for couples.

- It allows them to prioritize their efforts, focusing on effective resolution strategies for solvable issues, while learning to navigate and accept differences in unsolvable areas.
- This can lead to increased mutual understanding, improved communication, and a more harmonious relationship overall.
- Recognizing the nature of certain issues can reduce frustration and tension within the relationship.

What are some research-backed guidelines for handling conflict?

1. Be aware of confirmation bias

- Confirmation bias = when you gather evidence that reinforces your beliefs and disregard evidence that challenges your beliefs.

What are some research-backed guidelines for handling conflict?

2. Think about attributions

- We have a tendency to base our own mistakes on a particular situation, but we often base our partner's mistakes on a character deficiency.
- If I'm treating you poorly, it's because I had a bad day. If you're treating me poorly, it's because you're bad at relationships.

What are some research-backed guidelines for handling conflict

3. Avoid “never” and “always.”

- “You never do the dishes.”

4. One conflict issue at a time.

5. Focus on behaviors, not character.

What are some research-backed guidelines for handling conflict

6. Switch from reacting to reflecting.

- When you're having a conflict try telling the person you're speaking with what you heard them say.
 - In conflict, people often stop listening because they are planning their rebuttal.
- “What I’m hearing you say is that when I do this at these moments, you feel X.”
- Gottman’s XYZ strategy
 - When you do X in situation Y, I feel Z.

Defining power

Power

- The **ability to influence or control another person's behavior, thoughts, or emotions** (Burgoon, Buller, & Woodall, 1996).
 - Powerful = able to influence others

In close relationships, power is *not necessarily dominance or coercion* — it's a **dynamic process** that shifts over time and context.

- Relationships tend to be most satisfying when power is evenly distributed between partners.
 - Partners influence each other.

Power bases

Power Type	Source of Influence	Example
Coercive	Fear of punishment	"If you don't do this, I'll leave."
Reward	Promise of benefit	"If you do this, I'll buy you dinner."
Legitimate	Position or role	"Because I'm your manager..."
Expert	Perceived knowledge	"Trust me, I know this topic well."
Informational	Control of data or insight	"I know something you don't."
Referent	Emotional bond and admiration	"I'll do it because I care about you."

Referent power

- Referent power comes from identification, admiration, and emotional connection.
- It's the power you hold because others like you, respect you, or want to be associated with you.
- Often reciprocal — both partners influence each other out of love or respect.
- It predicts compliance without resentment — because influence feels relational, not coercive.

Power

- **Enabling power** – using expressive, composed behavior to influence others.
- Involves the ability to communicate self-confidence and competence.
- Uses interpersonal relationships to assist in achieving goals (“we’ve been good friends for such a long time, so you know how important this is to me”).
- People who use enabling power tend to be successful in achieving their goals and maintaining good relationships, especially over the long term.

Power

- **Disabling power** – using intimidation, threats, punishments, and other harsh tactics to influence others.
- The use of disabling power may be effective in the short term, but is not typically effective in the long term.
- Using disabling power tends to result in hurt feelings, resistance, resentment, and dissatisfaction.

Types of power dynamics in relationships

Type	Description	Example
Complementary Power	Each person has power in different areas.	“You plan the trip, I’ll handle the budget.”
Symmetrical Power	Both seek equal control	Joint decision-making about finances
Competitive Symmetry	Both fight for dominance	Frequent “Who’s right?” conflicts
Submissive Symmetry	Both avoid taking control	Indecision or lack of direction in the relationship

Types of power dynamics in relationships

Complementary power often works to enhance efficiency and harmony in a relationship

- Couples who appreciate each other's strengths — rather than compete for control — report higher satisfaction

Symmetrical power

- tends to promote *collaborative problem-solving*.

Verbal expressions of power

- **Directives:** “Do this,” “Let’s go here.”
- **Interruptions:** Trying to take conversational control.
- **Topic control:** Steering discussions toward one’s preferred outcomes.
- **Resistance messages:** Refusing compliance or pushing back.

Non-verbal expressions of power

- **Visual dominance ratio:** More eye contact while speaking than while listening.
- **Postural relaxation:** Taking up space, reclining — signaling confidence.
- **Touch initiation:** Higher-power individuals touch more often.
- **Vocalic control:** Louder, faster, lower-pitched speech can indicate dominance.

Power and technology

Temporal power

Unlike face-to-face, digital communication often does not require immediate response, giving the sender temporal power.

- Temporal power refers to the ability to control the timing, pace, or sequencing of interactions, which gives one partner influence over the other.

Delays, “seen” receipts, or ignoring messages can communicate dominance, disengagement, or testing boundaries.

Power and technology

Archival Power

- Social media creates a permanent record of interactions (posts, comments, photos).
- Archival power is the ability to exert influence or control through the preservation, access, or manipulation of records and past interactions.
- It comes from the existence of a “digital memory” — text messages, emails, social media posts, photos, videos, or shared documents.
- Individuals can leverage these records to influence behavior, perceptions, or decisions.

Power and technology

Enhanced informational power

Monitoring a partner's social media activity can increase informational power.

Five power principles

Power dynamics in close relationships can be conceptualized in terms of five principles.

- Power is dynamic
- Power principles illustrate the importance of egalitarian relationships.

Five power principles

1. Power as a perception

- Others are only powerful to the extent to which we think they are powerful.
- Do we believe that the person has the ability to influence others?

Five power principles

2. Power as a relational concept

- Power exists in all relationships
- People are most happy in equalitarian relationships
 - Though most romantic relationships involve small power imbalances
 - However, power is dynamic.

Five power principles

3. Power as resource based

- More resources = more power (ability to influence others).
- Traditionally conceptualized in terms of money. This narrow conceptualization has been criticized.
- Parenting ability, physical attractiveness, communication skill, sexual rewards

Five power principles, #3 continued

- The scarcity hypothesis
 - People have the most power when the resources they possess are hard to come by or in high demand.

Five power principles

- 4. Power as having less to lose
 - In a relationship, the person with less to lose has a greater amount of power

Five power principles, #4 continued

- Dependence power:
 - People who are dependent on their relationships and have low quality alternatives are in a powerless position

Five power principles, #4 continued

Principle of least interest

- the person who is more attracted and/or more in love has less power

Five power principles

- 5. Power as a prerogative:
 - the partner with more power can make and break the rules